

Minimalism

The idea that freedom from clutter should be the aim of all design goes back to the late 19th century, but it was not until the mid-20th century that the need to reduce elements and ornamentation really took hold. Minimalism was an important element of the modernist project from the outset, but notions of simplicity and purity in design developed further in the United States in the 1960s as some – artists as well as architects – reacted against what they saw as chaos in abstract expressionist art. Emerging more strongly in the 1980s, minimalist architecture never developing into a defined movement: merely a number of notable buildings around the world, such as Majorca's ochre-coloured Neuendorf House (1987–9) by John Pawson (b.1949) and Claudio Silvestrin (b.1954). The Burgo Tower in Porto (opposite, 2007) by Edouardo Souto de Moura (b.1952) juxtaposes vertical and horizontal elements, while the New Art Museum (2007) in New York, by Kazuyo Sejima (b.1956), is a stack of white boxes in various sizes and heights, giving the impression of a dynamic composition of giant cubes.

